What do you call this country of Amars, Akbars and Anthonys (or, if you want the Tamil equivalent, Shankars, Salims and Simons)? Ask director Shankar, and he'd say... what's in a name! His 1996 blockbuster was called *Indian* in Tamil, *Hindustani* in its Hindi avatar, and in Telugu, it became *Bharateeyudu*. Most of Indian cinema would agree with Shankar that the state matters, not the name. Shah Rukh Khan makes a *Chak De! India* (2007). He also made a *Phir Bhi Dil Hai Hindustani* (2000). Aamir Khan became *Raja Hindustani* (1996), while *Lagaan* (2001) had an extended title of 'Once Upon a Time in India', and another period epic called itself *Thugs of Hindostan* (2018).

Anil Kapoor's invisible superhero was called *Mr. India* (1987), while around the same time, on television, Shyam Benegal's series eschewed the English title of the book that it was based on (*The Discovery of India*) and called itself *Bharat Ek Khoj*. And the title of Episode 1? 'Long Live Mother India'. Nargis's iconic representation of the resilience of our women came in a film named *Mother India* (1957). The Malayalam actor Gopy, after receiving the National Award for Best Actor, was rechristened Bharat Gopy because it was popularly called the 'Bharat' award. Amitabh Bachchan debuted in a film about the exploits of seven Indians: *Saat Hindustani* (1969).

Sivaji Ganesan's 1973 feature about a building that housed people from all states was titled *Bharatha Vilas*, while its most famous song went "*Indiya naadu en veedu, Indian enbadhu en paeru...*" (India is my home, and I call myself an Indian). Why, then, the title of *Bharatha Vilas*? Perhaps because the term 'India' doesn't sit easily in the vernacular, despite that song. Take the Tamil nationalist poet, Subrahmanya Bharathi. In his poem '*Velli panimalayin...*' (referring to the Himalayas), the chorus says that we will pride ourselves on calling it part of our "*Bharatha desam*", our country Bharat.

Let's delve a little more into film songs. A very popular number in *Son of India* (1962) had the chorus 'Jai Hind'. We keep seeing this over and over, this conflation of India and Hind/Hindustani and Bharat. In the most famous song in *Purab Aur Paschim* (1970), Mr Bharat, a.k.a. Manoj Kumar, said he was a resident of Bharat, and he spoke about all things Bharat (*Bharat ka rehne wala hoon, Bharat ki baat sunata hoon*). So, at least from a cultural standpoint, we can presume the name of the country does not matter. Because one of our biggest uniters—films, film music—has never discriminated between the various names.

And this, apparently, is across ages. In *Sikandar-e-Azam* (1965), the story of Porus and Alexander, we have the hit "*Jahaan daal daal par sone ki chidiya*", with the chorus, "*woh Bharat desh hai mera*" (that is my Bharat). Indian cinema is not exactly known for historical accuracy, but let's take this song at face value. In 326 BC, 'Bharat' was what the country was called. Drag the timeline all the way to the modern day, to the computer era, in Subhash Ghai's NRI saga *Pardes* (1997), and we get a song with the chorus "I love my India".

But perhaps things have been changing of late. Look at Mahesh Babu in Koratala Siva's 2018 film about the commencement of *acche din* for the Telugu states. He is named Bharat Ram (the name of the country, and the name of one of its most revered rulers/ gods), and the film itself is titled *Bharat Ane Nenu* (I, Bharat). And in Hindi, Salman Khan's *Bharat* (2019) is the first big post-2014 film that can be used to make the case that 'Bharat' is going to be privileged over other names. In an early scene, the eponymous protagonist meets a broker who wants him to sell his small shop to developers with 'foreign' interests. The man is literally hung from a noose, and when you see the name of the shop, you see why. How can any self-respecting son of Bharat—especially one named after the country—tolerate this attempt to sell out... "Hind Ration Store"?

Note, also, *Uri: The Surgical Strike* (2019). True, the Paresh Rawal character, while referring to the valorous new nation (as opposed to the apparently timid older one), does not use the name 'Bharat', but he doesn't use 'India' either. Instead, he remarks, "*Yeh naya Hindustan hai. Yeh Hindustan ghar mein ghusega. Aur maarega bhi*" (This is a new Hindustan. It won't hesitate to kill). And how can the modern Mr Bharat—namely, Akshay Kumar—be far behind? His upcoming *Mission Raniganj: The Great Indian Rescue* has been renamed *Mission Raniganj: The Great Bharat Rescue*. A sign of the times? Time will tell. ■



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